PEGGY NOONAN

WHAT I SAW AT THE REVOLUTION

A Political Life in the Reagan Era

Random House Trade Paperbacks New York

TWELVE

"That's Not off My Disk"

By the summer of '85 I had been through the Three Phases of the White House.

The first is, "Gee these people are gonna be so smart," and you keep quiet so no one knows how dumb you are.

The second is, "Hey, I'm as bright as the other guys," and the affirmation makes you generous, the happy pride makes you nicer to the lady in the cafeteria. But you're also a little disappointed, because you wanted to learn.

The third is, "Oh my God, we're in charge?" And you start having mild anxiety attacks and talking too much.

At this point you redefine things, rearrange your concept of competence, knowing that this White House couldn't be worse than any of the others; it has it share of fools, but that's not new, and we always survive.

And you realize there isn't, as you'd thought when you were young and in school, a place full of excellence and truly superior people. There is no safe place of high merit. Because if it isn't here, it isn't.

. . .

I am at a meeting upstairs in the military situation room in the Old Executive Office Building. It is a big room, the kind a Hollywood producer would want to see before meeting with the production designer on what the *Strangelove* set should look like. The table that dominates the room is about thirty feet long and five feet wide. On the side, at each point where there is a chair, is a telephone and a little locked drawer. There is a sophisticated speaker system, a lectern with a microphone, a blank space above where maps or screens can be pulled down and displayed. Above are clocks giving the time in Washington, Moscow, and Greenwich Mean Time.

A dozen of us ring the table: Constantine Menges from the NSC, Bob Reilly from the Office of Public Liaison, Otto Reich from the State Department, a few more from State and from NSC, Ben Elliott, Pat Buchanan, me. It is a weekly meeting of midlevel administration officials on how to drum up public support for the anti-Sandinista resistance in Nicaragua.

In the spring of '85 the *contras* were as usual out in the field and going broke, and their supporters in America were as usual scrambling to think up new ways to capture the nation's interest and support. Thus the meetings, which were chaired by Pat Buchanan, though there was another who attempted to dominate, a dark-haired fellow in a crisp suit with bright eyes and a certain boyish quality.

He talked like no one I had ever heard. When he wanted to say he was not responsible for a specific memo, he snapped, "That's not off my disk." A suggested idea was a "notional," and getting something going was "ginning up." Someone suggested getting the leaders of the *contras* to go on a two-week tour of local news and talk shows in America, and he warned, "You'll never get Triple A to go along with it." I wondered what the American Automobile Association had to do with it. Later I realized he was referring to Adolfo Calero, Alfonso Robelo, and Arturo Cruz.

I leaned over and whispered to Ben, "Who's Peck's bad boy?"

"Don't you know Ollie?"

He was standing now, talking about a memo, saying things like, "And don't forget this is in accord conversation Casey-North approximately fifteen hundred this date."

Someone said something about the rebel leader Edén Pastora.

"Don't talk to me about Pastora, I'm not speaking to Pastora," he snapped.

I started to laugh. He looked at me like I was a girl.

Ollie had the sunny, undimmed confidence of a man who lacks insight into his own weaknesses. It is true you would want him in a foxhole with you because he would be brave and resourceful, and true you'd want him in the field, where he wouldn't run when the firing got heavy. But in an office, at the conference table, you just knew: That's where he'd get snookered. Metternich said it was no trick to outmaneuver those who think themselves clever, but it's hard to fool a completely honest man.

I went to the first meeting uninvited. Ollie had made it plain to Ben that he didn't want me there, Ben insisted and there I was.

I did not feel welcome; I was not supposed to. When a sensitive document was distributed, handed from one fellow to another along the table, I half stood to reach for my copy when the man next to me seemed to forget to pass it on. He looked at the paper, looked at Ollie, and said, "There is some obviously sensitive material here which, if it fell into the wrong hands, could be embarrassing or misleading. This is a whole formal-looking schedule of presidential activities that hasn't even been okayed, but if someone got a hold of it . . ."

There was silence. I sat down. Someone said, "Why don't we hand them in at the end of the meeting?" I was given a copy. Which I did not hand back in. Nor did anyone else. But the message had been delivered.

I barely said a word at the meetings. There was some I'm Tougher than You, mostly from Ollie to Otto, the man from State. Otto is a solid, low-key type, and Ollie seems to take low-key for weak: he acts at moments as if he thinks Otto's one of those cookie-pushing faggots from Foggy Bottom who don't know diddlysquat about what's happening on the ground.

He ignores me in a way that is hard to ignore, looking past me when he speaks, at the man to my right when I do. I make believe I don't notice. I am unfailingly pleasant. I am probably too pleasant. He probably thinks I'm another cookie-pushing faggot.

Ollie told a story: Recently at a big Democratic gathering a congressman with a few too many drinks in him approached Tip O'Neill and told him—Ollie stops. And looks at me. "I can't repeat what he said in front of a lady."

The men around me are embarrassed. "Come on Ollie, tell."

"Tell," I say.

Ollie, with a blank face, says, "The congressman supposedly told O'Neill, 'You're gonna lose Central America for us and they'll blame our party you fat old . . . SOB!' "

"What did the fat son of a bitch say?" I ask pleasantly.

Everyone laughs. Except Ollie, who does not answer.

I always used to wonder when I was in the White House when I would finally pass in the hall a meeting, or have a short conversation that turned out, in retrospect, to be touched by dark history—like the secretary in the office next to John Dean hearing, "Mr. Liddy is here to see you, John," or overhearing in the hall, "Don Segretti, how are you, going to see Mr. Colson?" I guess the *contra* meetings were my moment, but I wound up taking notes on how people talked.

We made a list of our assets and someone said the biggest asset was obviously President Reagan. We talked about having the president make a speech in the Orange Bowl in Miami on the anniversary of JFK's famous speech after the Bay of Pigs. There was hopeful talk that we might inspire a commitment on the part of the American people.

We were full of ideas. Getting more congressional delegations to tour the refugee camps in Honduras, getting the editor of *La Prensa* to speak before editorial boards of American newspapers and TV and radio stations. Gather together famous Democrats who supported the U.S. position on the *contras*—Ed Koch, Bob Strauss, members of the bipartisan Kissinger Commission, the CIA and NSC directors since Nixon—to meet with the president in the Oval Office and then march with him into the Rose Garden, do a quick photo, and then have a brief, pungent statement by the president reading off the names of his guests and arguing that support of the *contras* is bipartisan and necessary, then asking the Democrats to mix with reporters.

Someone suggested having the president go down to House Speaker Jim Wright's district and argue the case for the democratic resistance, ending his comments, according to my notes, with something like 'Blank miles from here is the Alamo, where brave heroes blank, and where the commander of the garrison wrote during those terrible last days blank. It is accepted wisdom to say we are less than they were and that the issues that face us are less clear, but we're not and they're not. The issues are still clear; and we are still great."

Then, on the upcoming vote to offer military assistance to the *contras:* "This is more than a vote, more than an appropriation of money. This is a sign, a declaration, a commitment. We have drawn a line in the sand: this far and no farther. The Communists and communism must be expunged from the clean, free lands of the Americas."

It is odd to see that rhetoric now, to remember my conviction only five years ago that the problem of Central America was not only of the most profound but of the most *immediate* implications, that it was the place where communism would either tragically advance north, toppling little government after little government and creating a wave of foot people, or be stopped. Perhaps that was—and is—true. But now, at the beginning of the nineties, the Sandinistas seem weak and beset, their Soviet instructors distracted, the *contras* are almost gone, the Ortegas of the world seem antique, as old-fashioned as Fidel, the Beijing spring has inspired both right and left in the West to declare communism profoundly reactionary, the rhetoric of the day is the rhetoric of peace and the theater of the day is Europe, and NATO. Or so it seems.

What we most hoped for was a live presidential address on prime-time television in the days before the congressional vote. The Senate would vote first, and if the president could speak before then, who knows? What was needed was something different, not bellicose, not "rhetoric"—a thoughtful speech addressing real questions, including, I hoped, one we had never addressed: If Cuba has been Communist for a quarter-century now and everything's pretty much okay, why are you making such a big deal about Nicaragua? What's the difference? This is the kind of question normal people have.

All we had to do was get Deaver to okay it.

The meetings proceeded twice a week for a few weeks when, suddenly, trouble: Someone has leaked information regarding disagreements between State and the NSC on the *contras.* I am anxious; I am the person from CBS. Do they suspect me? Buchanan and the man from State are looking at me. I feel guilty.

I am one of those people who always feel guilty when something bad is done. When I was a child in school and someone stole candy, I was the one who couldn't keep eye contact with the teacher. I am convinced that if I ever had to take a lie-detector test, I would fail because when asked the critical question—Did you in fact pick up a knife and

attempt to kill John Smith?—all the electrical impulses in my body would jump the jump of the guilty. I don't know why this is, but let me take a stab, as it were: People talk of Jewish guilt, but it is nothing compared to Irish-Catholic shame.

I stare back. Pause. Meeting resumes. Until a few weeks later when there is a front-page exclusive by Jeremiah O'Leary in the *Washington Times:* Administration heating up *contra* support, big Orange Bowl date set, major presidential address likely, etc.

Don Regan blew up at the morning staff meeting. He is proud of his leak-proof administration and can't stand it when things like this happen. Buchanan is rattled; somehow he is always in trouble.

Mike Deaver, who did not hide his political and personal aversion for Buchanan, was said to be leaking against him most energetically in the press. (Pat later retaliated by calling Deaver "Lord of the Chamber Pot.") Now Deaver was said to be spreading word that whether the president backs Pat on his Central America stuff is a crucial test of Pat's importance. Then Deaver could perhaps see to it that Pat failed and encourage press stories on Buchanan's fall from grace. So much of it came down to personalities; so much of history comes down to who likes who.

We never found who leaked to the *Washington Times.* It could have been a fool on our side who thought he could force the White House to take action; it could have been someone who knew Regan would be infuriated by the leak and scuttle the project; it could have been someone who merely wanted to ingratiate himself with a reporter. Whatever, the leak changed the realities. There were no more meetings of the Buchanan group. Deaver rejected the idea of a speech, no doubt buttressed by polling data that said the *contras* weren't popular. We lost that vote in Congress. And Ollie, it turns out, had other ideas.

The question of the *contras* was yet another expression of the conservative/pragmatist split, the division that cleaved the administration from its first day. The ideologues versus the Republicans, the young guys versus the old guys—whatever you called it, what it all came down to was a continuing disagreement over which issues should be pursued and what actions taken.

No one wanted the *contras* to lose, no one wanted the Sandinistas to flourish, but there was plenty of disagreement on whether to devote a great deal of time and effort to the issue.

"We have to pick easy issues so he can keep rolling up victories, and maintain the air of invincibility!"

"No, pick the hard ones that count, they're what we're here for, and dammit, political capital can't be hoarded—use it or lose it!"

I usually lined up with the latter view, though not always. I understood the importance in a fiercely political town of maintaining the aura. But if a president doesn't use his popularity, if he just keeps it in a safe-deposit box and takes it out at night to marvel at how it reflects the light, he loses his power to make good change.

The pragmatists thought you couldn't win on an issue when you'd lost *The Washington Post* and the networks. The conservatives thought you could win without them—by going over the heads of the media, as it were, to the people.

All you have to do is a speech in which you clearly and frankly present your side of the argument and then anticipate what your critics will say. As a matter of fact, say it for them, state their reservations fairly and answer them. If you do it honestly and with respect—and if you're right—the people will follow.

You don't have to be afraid of the media. John Chancellor has the right to think and say what he likes, the White House has the right to disagree, and the country has the right to referee, to call a TKO or order them back to their corners.

There were real issues disagreements. The pragmatists were generally moderate liberals in the area of what is clumsily called "values." They thought, Downplay that social-issues stuff; it makes us lose more ground with baby boomers and opinion leaders. The conservatives thought no, pursue those issues, with the right arguments we can convince the majority—when we don't have it already.

The pragmatists said, That's just your agenda.

The conservatives said, That's Ronald Reagan's agenda, and he won!

Complicating the conservative-pragmatist split was Ronald Reagan himself, who seemed to allow his top aides to forget what and who he'd long been. Once at a senior staff meeting during the second administration, someone mentioned a decision and mused, typically, "I wonder what the conservatives will think?" An aide leaned forward and said, "Gee, I don't know, let's go ask the president!"

Religion was another dividing issue, a quiet one. This is a small story that highlights it. It happened after I left.

THE CONSERVATIVE AND THE PRAGMATISTS AT THE ISSUES LUNCH

Talk about your different views of reality!

Talk about your two completely different and irreconcilable views of what the facts of America are!

Talk about Gary Bauer at the issues lunch.

It is late in the second administration, and Gary Bauer, conservative activist and domestic-policy aide to the president, is raring to go. It is Monday in the Cabinet Room, and the president is meeting with top staff for the weekly issues lunch, at which important questions and events of the previous and coming weeks will be discussed.

The preceeding Friday at 2:00 P.M. each aide had submitted, according to form, a one-page preview of the issue he wished to discuss. These were reviewed by an aide to the chief of staff, who put them in a blue binder, which was forwarded to the president for weekend review. Sometimes an aide would be asked to rewrite his submission— "I really think it would be better for you, Joe, if you remove that one sentence, because Bob might really take offense." Sometimes a submission wasn't included. Sometimes you weren't told why.

In this meeting Gary Bauer wanted to discuss a topic he thought might not be too popular with his colleagues. In order not to raise alarms he refrained from asking in his submission for any presidential action ("Please meet with," "Please send letter to"). Recently he had taken to writing out his discussion point on an issue he thought would be accepted. Then, when called on, he would ease his way into talking about the unscheduled topic he really wanted to discuss.

Today, when called upon to discuss his issue (once he had been fourth or fifth on line, but now that it was known he was not always predictable he was next to last; they often didn't get to him), he burrowed in. A child in a public school down South had been chosen as valedictorian of her class and wished, at graduation, to do a speech on the importance of God in her life. School authorities, perceiving in this a breach of the separation of church and state, said no.

"Mr. President, this is exactly the sort of issue we should be discussing . . . the right of a child in our public schools to make a simple reference to her faith and to the Lord."

As Bauer spoke, he became aware of a silence. He looked around the table. His colleagues were embarrassed for him. Here they were assem-

bled in the White House, ready to talk about serious things like the Soviets, and here's poor Gary telling him about some little kid in East Jesus.

They started to look at each other and laugh. The tittering spread. The president looked at them. They quieted.

Sometimes at these luncheons the president did not seem to be paying all that much attention. Sometimes he pushed the food on his plate. "It's understandable," said an aide. "These meetings are usually boring." The president no longer felt free to make his views known because in the first years of the administration he would find reports of what he'd said in the next day's newspapers. The leaks had dismayed him. Now friends such as Ed Meese would help him out when someone finished with an issue. "The president will take that under advisement, thank you."

"Mr. President," said Bauer, "there's something terribly wrong when an American child is silenced for trying to say what the president says in speeches every day."

Reagan was not bored; he was listening closely. "I want to do something about this," he said. "Is there anything I can do?"

"Of course."

"Gee, I'd like to help her."

"To meet with her would be fantasic. Or you could send her a letter."

"Let's do that."

The final letter said:

> Dear Angela,
>
> I read of the events surrounding your proposed commencement address with considerable interest. Like you, I have long believed in the paramount importance of faith in God.
>
> Angela, your actions on behalf of your religious convictions demonstrate not only the strength and passion of those convictions, but your admirable personal courage in facing those who have challenged you. I know that it is often difficult to stand up for one's beliefs when they are being harshly challenged. But as one who has seen many challenges over a long lifetime, I can assure you that personal faith and conviction are strengthened, not weakened, in adversity.
>
> Nancy and I wish you well throughout your life. God bless you.

It was signed "Ronald Reagan."

• • •

Why the laughter at the issues lunch? And why did Gary Bauer continue when it made him look foolish in the eyes of his peers?

The men who laughed had no hostility to religion. They made sure their children went to Sunday school or mass, and if not intensely spiritual themselves, you could bet that each had along the way "had a few talks with the fellow upstairs." But they felt this issue had been settled once and for all by the Supreme Court, and there was nothing to be gained by refighting it.

There was also, I believe, a bit of ye olde class antagonism at work. These nice men in their blue suits from Brooks would be embarrassed to acknowledge it but there was something distressingly trailer park about these fundamentalists and their ferocity and their I VISITED HERITAGE VILLAGE T-shirts. Such—bumptuous credulity, such smugness. To be on their side was to play the role Fredric March played in *Inherit the Wind,* when the hero of that movie, as we all know, was Spencer Tracy.

But Bauer saw an America in which the habit of religion has been removed from public life, in which the innocent expression of religious sentiment is banned by lawyers wielding documents the way Carry Nation waved her ax, to separate daily life from the grip of . . . spirits!

He thought that a seemly tolerance is in order, that religion after all tends to be a civilizing force, that those who worship intellectual achievement and man-made systems had been allowed to push their "fastidious disdain" down the nation's weary throat. He thought the administration was insufficiently alive not only to a legitimate issue of fairness and justice but a significant political reality: Show some identification with this sector of the electorate, and you'll awaken a lion.

But what was the nature of that lion? The men around the table who laughed feared the unleashing of the John Browns with all their crazed certitude, the unleashing of the profoundly illiberal impulses of—well, after all, this *is* the nation where Elmer Gantry was drawn from real life!

They didn't want to once again have to defend their administration to Elizabeth Drew and have that intelligent woman look at them with a sniff, didn't want to have to get on the shuttle to make a speech and see some guy from *Nightline* who'd say, "Well you guys lost New York

this week!," didn't want to go to the barbecue with the neighbor who's a lawyer who stands poking the hot dogs and asking, "Why you people have to make appeals to those—those narrow-minded little people with a rather impressive history of anti-Semitism and racism, I'm really surprised you're on their side," and so on.

But when Bauer looked at those who would like to use a public schoolroom for Bible study after school hours, or put a crèche on the public square, he saw America, the America we've always been until things went crazy, an America of decent, undemanding people who'd been stunned and disoriented by the Carry Nations and *their* crazed certitude.

In a way it was a disagreement about what kind of behavior is narrow-minded, and who is narrow-minded, and what narrow-minded is.

The conservatives were sometimes embarrassed by their own constituency. The pragmatists were embarrassed by the funny feeling they got sometimes at 3:00 A.M.: If I'm on the side of liberality and openness, why am I on the side that's doing the not allowing?

You could see the conservative/pragmatist split here too, in a meeting Ronald Reagan held with members of the conservative community during the second administration.

The meeting, in the Roosevelt Room, followed an angry telephone conversation between the presidential aide Ken Duberstein and Paul Weyrich of the Free Congress Foundation. Duberstein, an affable and highly regarded Republican political operative, had been brought back to the White House after the departure of Donald Regan. He had run the White House congressional liaison operation in the first administration, where he had enjoyed considerable success.

Now, after a string of recent White House failures—Daniloff, Iran-*contra*, the failure to capitalize on the public support of Oliver North following his testimony, the Bork debacle—conservative frustration had reached such a pitch that the Weyrich-Duberstein phone call had ended with the former hanging up on the latter.

Duberstein reported to the president on the phone call and the president decided to call Weyrich and hear his criticisms firsthand.

Weyrich had given it to him both barrels. (Weyrich is a man not undone by presidents and princes; his commitment quite defeats any impulse he might have to defer.) He told friends after the call, "I have

good news and bad news. The good news: The president is not senile. He was vigorous and sounded fully engaged by the topics discussed. The bad news is that he is almost completely misinformed; the worst news is that he does not know this and appears to doubt it."

The president agreed to Weyrich's request for a meeting with conservative activists, who decided to devote the hour to three topics; the *contras*, SDI, and Mozambique.

The mood: the conservatives were both feisty and hopeful. They had never got over their love for Ronald Reagan, and would never forget that when no one in the country would go against the current wisdom it was he alone of national politicians who'd held true. On the other hand they'd known him for years and shrugged: You know how he is.

The presidential aides with whom they'd meet were also conservative. But they had spent a lifetime on the Hill. The small *c* conservatives believed that action must follow consensus. The big *C* Conservatives said consensus follows action. (Moreover, they said, You guys don't even try to build consensus, you just hope to find it in the polls!)

The small *c* conservatives had been doing yeomans' work on the Hill when conservative ideas there didn't have a chance. Their way of operating had been forged in defeat; Republicans come of age during Vietnam and Watergate, they were used to losing, and saw part of their job as limiting the loss. Dammit, they thought, I was doing the hard work of politics when you guys were sitting around writing think pieces for Dysentary! You guys were playing with theory while I was up to my ass in the art of the possible with Bobby Byrd!

Each side felt unappreciated by the other. Each side was right. Thus the epithets, spoken in private: Reactionary! Unprincipled hack! Dammit, if it weren't for us you never would have gotten your precious tax cuts through Congress! Dammit, if it weren't for you we would have had a realignment!

Howard Baker and his men approached the Roosevelt Room in one long sigh. First we get beat up by Jim Wright, now we get beat up by Jim Right!

The Conservatives had fielded a worthy crew: the scientist Robert Jastrow, with his quick Columbia University brightness; the activist Grover Norquist; the philanthropist Bob Krieble, a man with a genuinely serious mind who could discourse with sureness on anything from Adam Smith to the history of helium; William Kennedy, publisher of

the *Conservative Digest;* and Huck Walther of a conservative defense committee.

Into the room marched the president, accompanied by Duberstein, Howard Baker, Frank Carlucci, Paul Laxalt (the president's unofficial liaison to the right; if the meeting degenerated, it would be Laxalt, respected on both sides, who could say as no one else, "Now boys . . ."), and Caspar Weinberger.

The president opened the meeting without three by five cards. "This is your meeting. We wanted to get together and discuss some of your concerns."

Two Conservatives talked about the *contras*. The White House had missed an opportunity to get *contra* aid when it refused to move after the public ground swell of support after Ollie North's testimony.

The president answered, But public opinion wasn't behind more *contra* aid even after Ollie's testimony. "Dick Wirthlin's polls—and he's the best, most accurate pollster in the country—showed that we didn't have the popular support even after Ollie."

When the president had made just this point to Weyrich a week before, Weyrich had answered, "If public opinion was the decider in this country you'd have gun control and prayer in the schools. In fact, public policy is driven by small, concentrated, highly motivated groups of activists who focus their political energies on these questions. If you had moved, we would have moved—and we would have won."

Now someone answered the president saying the popularity of Ollie North's position was better illustrated by the football stadiums full of people who were stopping the game and cheering when planes came overhead with banners saying OLLIE FOR PRESIDENT—that a point had been reached at which every marginal vote, every swing vote, would have swung our way, where every senator with his finger in the wind would have felt a hurricane!

We had the votes, we could have won, said a participant.

Your vote-counters don't know what they're doing, they've been historically bad, said another.

The back and forth was vigorous. The president promised to keep in touch on strategy.

On SDI, a participant said, Mr. President, you ought to announce you're going for immediate deployment of SDI. If JFK had said, "We're going to research going to the moon," he never would have gotten funding, not to mention support. You ought to say we're going

to have a defensive shield that will stop incoming missiles before this decade is out.

The president shook his head. Again, he said, I have to note that we just lack public support for SDI.

Jastrow leaned forward: *No one goes to the barricades for research funding!* Tell the people over and over what SDI can do, how it can protect us, and tell them we're going to deploy at least some parts before the decade is out.

The secretary of defense turned to the president. "There is of course the argument that the Soviets are simply trying to slow us down long enough to get their SDI in place. I don't mean to suggest they're doing it consciously, but by holding up strategic defense, the Democrats in Congress are doing the work of the Soviet Union for them. I don't mean to say they're doing it consciously, but—"

"Well, I will," said Reagan. Everyone laughed. (Reagan the paradox, cautious in strategy and incautious in his comments. Why does he say these things? If he really feels the Democrats are helping the Soviets, why doesn't that add a sense of urgency to his position on SDI? And if he doesn't think it, why does he say it?)

Now the presentation of the youngest person there, Grover Norquist, thirtyish, Harvard-educated, a free-lance Conservative operative.

With ten minutes to brief his first president, Grover had called around to friends who had worked in the White House and asked, How do I keep his attention on a subject he may not find naturally interesting? The day of the meeting he gave a presentation in which the president was forced to look at a picture, read a short letter or respond to a question. All this not so much so Grover would keep his attention, but so the president's staff would notice he'd kept his attention. "I wanted them to know the president had heard my arguments and would remember them, so they'd have to take that into account when they discussed Mozambique with him."

He captivated the president with a kind of show-and-tell on Mozambique—that the governing party is Marxist-Leninist; President Chissano is a Communist. You may have been given the impression by the State Department, which tends in its worldview to assume a black African is too dumb to be a Communist, to think that's only for white Europeans—you may have been given the impression that the people of the Mozambique government are not serious. But they are.

But there is a strong opposition, he said, a guerrilla army with

twenty-two thousand men under arms, the fastest-growing anti-Communist insurgency in the world. It is pro-democratic and pro-Western in its outlook.

"Sir, this is a picture I took of one section of a very large official government mural that is placed very prominently on the highway between the airport and Maputo, the capital. The mural is placed alongside the Plaza of Heroes, which every person who enters Mozambique must pass as he leaves the airport. As you can see, this part of the mural shows a white man with a Star of David very prominent on his military cap. He is strangling and manacling a young black man. The message is obvious: Zionism is the enemy."

He handed the photo to the president.

"Mr. President, the government of Mozambique has picked up all the Soviet Union's bad habits, from concentration camps to secret police to anti-Semitism. These are decisions and positions the Soviets tell them to take. By the way, I asked a high official of the government why anti-Semitic art is part of an official government poster. He said, 'Oh, the artist did that.' "

Reagan was studying the eight-by-ten color glossy.

"Mr. President, did anyone ever tell you of this mural?"

"No."

"Well, Mr. President, you can't miss it."

The president asked if he could keep the photo. At that point, for the first time in the meeting, Weinberger, Carlucci and Howard Baker picked up their pencils and wrote on their white White House pads.

"Mr. President, they have East Germans running the secret police, and you know and I know who East Germans are. They're Nazis without the charm."

The president laughed. Howard Baker wrote on his pad, "Nazis without the charm." He underlined it.

The president said, "Well, I fought the Communists years ago in the Screen Actors Guild, and I understand them." He told a story of how he had to carry a gun for a year. He said there was a plan by some of the Communists in the union to throw acid in his face so he'd never be able to work in pictures again.

"Well, they were successful," Weyrich said dryly. "You haven't made a picture in years."

Everyone laughed, and stood to leave. Norquist walked around the table to the president.

"Sir, when you meet with President Chissano in October, keep one thing in mind: Chissano used to be the head of security in Mozambique, and in that capacity he once had one of his lieutenants murder his own father in front of a thousand government troops to teach them what revolutionary discipline really means. Do you know how the man killed his father?"

Reagan shook his head. Norquist drew an imaginary dagger from his belt, pointed it toward the president's abdomen and traced up and over.

The president winced and stepped back.

"So remember," said Norquist, "when you meet with Chissano: plastic cutlery."

You've noticed that in some of the stories in this book there are three little words that pop up, "Dick Wirthlin's polls."

I am going to break into "seriousness" here, and I'm afraid this may seem dull because it starts with things you know. But it may end with things you don't, so stay with me.

Polls are the obsession of every modern White House and every political professional, Republican and Democratic, I know. In every political meeting I have ever been to, if there was a pollster there his words carried the most weight because he is the only one with hard data, with actual numbers on actual paper.

Everyone else has an opinion; the pollster has a fact.

Every modern president has kept an eye on his approval ratings, but in the eighties it reached critical mass. When I left the Reagan White House I felt that polls are now driving more than politics, they are driving history.

There is nothing wrong with taking the temperature of the electorate in order to know how the people of a vast nation feel about an issue. Lincoln himself said, "Public opinion is everything," and he might have appreciated having such a sophisticated tool to help guide him in how to achieve an objective.

But we would like to think—in fact, we know—that he would not have used polls to tell him whether to pursue the objective, or whether it was worth pursuing.

In our time leaders throughout the government are advised by their aides to fight for something or not fight for it depending on the chances of victory as suggested by the polls.

This is not so bad, you say—at least it means leaders are tied directly

to the will of the people, which is what pure democracy is. But no it's not. Pure democracy is a constant argument, an unending tug of war over what is right and how and whether to achieve it.

One of the reasons Lincoln was great is that he would have looked at the data presented by his pollster and said something like, "I see they're against the war, so I guess I'll have to communicate the argument for keeping the Union together better than I have." He would not have said "Gee, they're against it—guess I better not spend my capital on a losing game just to help the Negroes!"

The chief tool of the pollster looking for an in-depth sense of the views of the people is the focus group. A modern focus group is, simply, a group of a dozen or so citizens invited to attend a meeting at which they are asked to answer questions regarding their feelings on public issues as honestly as they can, and for which they're often paid a nominal fee.

There is a focus-group leader who asks questions—Do you know who the *contras* are and what country they're in? How do you feel about them? Does Michael Dukakis seem to you to be an honest person? Does it seem that he knows what he's talking about?

As the people answer and comment, the proceedings are quietly videotaped, so political professionals back in Washington can view the people at their leisure. They put a great deal of store in what they see. It's one of the few times they get to see "the people." They live Washington lives, they're not out there.

All this may sound benign, and in some ways it is.

But it also means: Do you know who's in charge now in America? The guys who sat around in Paddy Chayefsky's *Marty* saying, "I don't know, Marty, whatta you wanna do?"

The pollsters, conveying the words and will of Marty and the guys, seem like populists—Hear the voice of the people!—when in fact they are missing a few essential elements.

Marty and the guys *themselves* know you can't find out from the people what to do about, say, the drug problem, because they don't know. That's what they pick leaders for, to come up with answers. Do they have opinions? Sure, and they'll share them. They'll also tell you, "But I haven't spent my life studying this."

The fact is, if you stopped time and pulled them out of the dialogue in the luncheonette and told them the impact of what they're saying, they'd say, "Ya mean we're in charge? Then something's screwed up!".

And if perchance, oh, Edmund Burke happened to stroll in and say,

"Your representative owes you not his industry only, but his judgment; and he betrays you instead of serving you if he sacrifices it to your opinion," Marty and his friends would most likely say, "You got that right, Bubba."

There's more. A focus group in 1863 would have backed a negotiated peace with the Confederates. A focus group in 1963 would have frowned on Martin Luther King, Jr., taking to the streets of Birmingham. Focus groups can communicate opinion, but they cannot tell you what is right.

And is even the opinion they convey "right"? The dynamic of a focus group is like that of any group: People sometimes act as if they have an opinion when they really don't but think maybe they should, or get pulled along a little by the fellow who speaks with sureness. A lot of what gets said reflects momentary swirls of culture and style and what they overheard on TV.

It is not only the men around modern leaders who are in the thrall of polls and popularity ratings. The press too trumpet these ratings; they are believed by everyone in Washington to mean something. When asked if a public figure is doing well, it is not unusual for a Strobe Talbot to say on a *Washington Week*, "Yes, he has very high approval ratings." The media's approval buttresses the pollster's standing.

The aides are like this because they know their principals want to be liked, and it's always nice to be able to offer proof—hard data!—of the electorate's ardor. But they also do it for history: They do it so history will say their presidents were popular, because they think popularity equals success.

And here's the funny thing: History won't be fooled. If Lincoln had ended a war to please the people, history would not call him a giant—though yes, his popularity ratings in the spring of '63 would have been considerably higher, and Mrs. Lincoln might have been in a better mood more of the time.

Here's the final funny thing: Being led by the polls isn't practical. Because when you rule by the polls, the people can finally tell. The fact is it's practical to do what you think is right and keep talking to the people honestly about it. It's practical to believe in something. Because the people can tell. They're distracted but they're smart, and they can tell as time passes when you're sincere and led by principle.

And they honor these things even if they can't always articulate their approval at focus-group meetings.